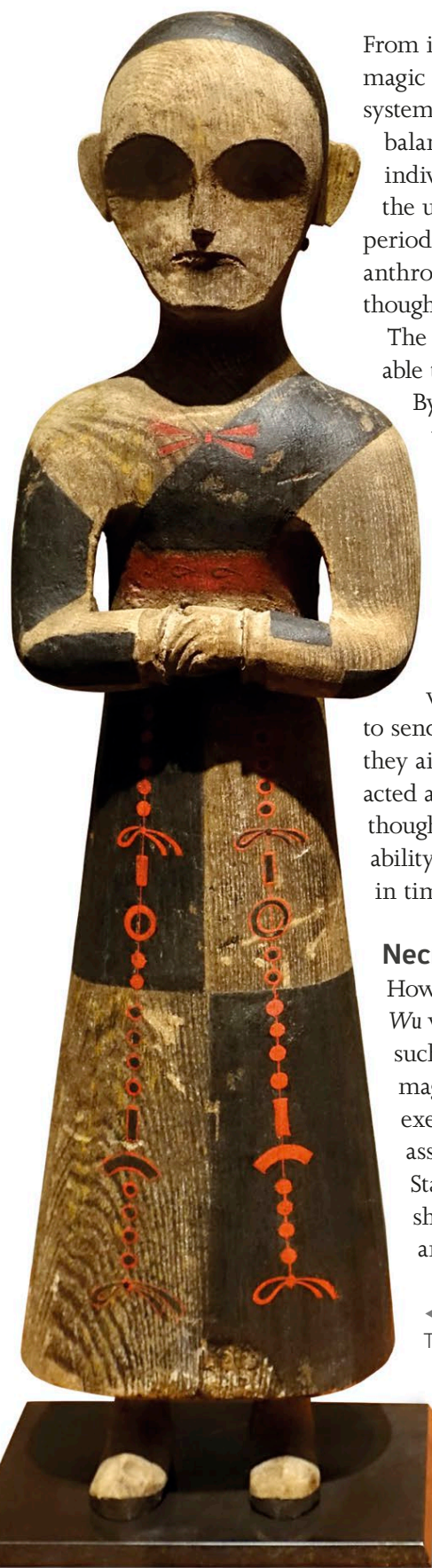


# ELIXIRS OF LIFE AND DEATH

ancient Chinese magic



From its roots in ancestor worship, Chinese magic developed into a sophisticated philosophical system that acknowledged the need to achieve balance in the cosmos; magic was a way for individuals to gain a personal advantage within the universe. From as early as the Yangshao period (5000–3000 BCE), ceramics depicted anthropomorphic (resembling humans) creatures thought to represent sorcerers.

The first Chinese magicians were wu (shamans), able to communicate with ancestors and spirits.

By the Shang Dynasty (1600–1050 BCE), the wu appeared to have a more formal role in the interpretation of oracles. A shaman named Wu Xian was reported to have been in charge of divination at the court of Tang, the first Shang ruler. The Zhouli (a Chinese ritual text), also refers to Managers of the Spirit Mediums, who supervised the work of the wu. The wu—who were often female—performed rituals to send themselves into an ecstatic trance in which they aimed to travel to the spirit world. They also acted as healers and dream interpreters, and were thought to have powers over nature, such as the ability to invoke rain through special dance rituals in times of drought.

## Necromancy and popular magic

However, the monopoly of the wu did not last. Wu were alleged to have been involved in scandals such as Empress Chen Jia's use of wugu (dark magic). She was convicted and 300 wu were executed. Such accusations increased the wu's association with witchcraft. After the Warring States Period (403–221 BCE), new forms of shaman, the xi, who were all male, appeared, and the wu were marginalized.

### ◀ Wooden shaman figure

This is one half of a pair of wu tomb attendants from the Chu kingdom, one of the Warring States. It dates from the 4th or 3rd century BCE. The kingdom continued to practice shamanism long after other parts of China stopped, perhaps influenced by the shamans of northeast Asia and Siberia.

Officials called shi had long had a role in rituals honoring the dead, in which the spirit of the deceased was channeled through their body in a kind of necromancy, and chi (who uttered incantations) came to play the role of priests. Over time, the use of incantations, spells, and potions (especially love philters) devolved to folk magic, in which charms and amulets were used to invoke gods or summon ancestors. Magic also came to be used alongside conventional medicine as substances such as amber and peach wood, believed to have magical curative properties, were employed.

## From shamans to sorcery

Accusations that they were involved in ku (casting harmful spells) played a part in the downfall of the wu. Fears of sorcerers employing dark magic, in particular for poisoning, had first appeared in oracle

